

CHAPTER 3: BEHIND THE VEIL

Dawn arrived in Los Angeles like a forensic team—cold, uninvited, and looking for reasons to blame the victim. By the time the sky turned the color of a bruised municipal apology, I was still hunched over the desk, watching the drive's light flicker on the air-gapped laptop like a digital pulse. No bourbon. Just the taste of old copper and parish coffee that had died an hour ago. The office looked worse in the morning light. Night is a PR firm; it handles the optics. Dawn is the audit. It itemized the cigarette burns on the mahogany, the nicotine-stained peeling of the wallpaper, and the typewriter in the corner with the broken plastic princess jammed in the carriage—a tiny, decapitated saint of interrupted language. I reached into the desk drawer and pulled out the .38. I didn't need it for a fight yet, but I needed the weight of it. Steel doesn't lie. It doesn't use "pathways" or "sensitivities". It has one function and zero euphemisms. I set it on the legal pad, a heavy anchor against the digital voodoo on the screen. Victoria had organized the material with the ritualized precision of a suicide note. Nested folders. Image caches. Legal frameworks. She hadn't just stolen Kingston Global's data; she'd curated a map of her own moral corrosion. I bypassed the encrypted journal and went straight for the VISUAL / BACK OF HOUSE folder. No more digital theory. I wanted the physical receipts of the rot. I found it buried in a subfolder labeled "Sanitization Logistics." It wasn't a "continuity sensitivity report". It was a bill. A PDF from a "Sanitization Specialist" out of Glendale, charging thirty-five hundred dollars for "Deep Clean & Structural Neutralization" at an address in Echo Park. I knew the address. It was a safe house I'd used back when the Heartland story was still breathing. The bill didn't mention children. It mentioned "hazardous organic residue" and "narrative hygiene protocols". This wasn't corporate theory; this was a cleaning crew scrubbing a crime scene before the blood could dry into a headline. The "Sanitization Specialist" wasn't a janitor. He was a professional eraser of context. I scrolled further. A "Protective Routing" memo. In the original draft, it looked like bureaucracy. Now, I saw the physical consequences. It was a spreadsheet of "Asset-Adjacent Populations"—kids. Beside one name, a girl named Maya, was a handwritten note in the margin: Stabilized via Tier 3 intervention. Relocated to Pallas Medical. No further contact authorized.. "Stabilized" was corporate voodoo for "drugged or disappeared". I closed my eyes and was back in Moss's office. It had the same pressurized silence as this digital archive. I could still smell the expensive restraint of his cologne and the ozone of the new newsroom architecture that had replaced the ink and sweat of the old world. "What am I looking at?" Moss had asked, his manicured finger hovering over the binder. "County-linked trafficking," I'd said. "Judicial cover. The whole machine". Moss hadn't flinched. He'd just uncapped a cheap red pen—the only cheap thing in the room—and drew a line through my name. "This story dies here, Duke," he'd said. "Power does not fear truth. It updates around it". Back then, I thought he was being clever. Now, looking at the bill for the Glendale cleaning crew, I realized he was just reading the

manual. Kingston wasn't a person; it was an adaptive grammar with payroll. I opened Victoria's encrypted journal. Password prompt. I didn't try her birthday. I didn't try Kingston's. I thought like a woman who saw her own soul as a liability. I typed: witness. The file opened. No grand confession. Just a ledger of the dead. I have begun to understand that the company is not the structure, she wrote. The company is a face. Marcus is a face. The charity is a face. Faces are inexpensive. What matters is the vocabulary and the reserve channels behind it. The burner phone on the desk buzzed once. Not a ring. A vibration that felt like a localized earthquake. Blocked message. One line: DO NOT OPEN THE AUDIO FILES ON A LIVE NETWORK. I looked at the air-gapped laptop, then at the .38. Whoever sent that message knew where I was, or they knew what was on this drive well enough to enjoy the show. Then came the knock. Three measured taps on the office door. Not the rhythmic pounding of the LAPD. Not the frantic kick of a landlord. Measured. Administrative. The room changed shape. I didn't reach for the mouse. I reached for the steel. "Package for Savage," a voice said through the wood. Neutral. Young. The kind of voice that belongs to someone who has never been told no by the law. I didn't answer. I waited for the footsteps to retreat before I moved. The padded envelope lay on the floor like a dropped lung. Inside was a glossy, telephoto shot of Victoria and me leaving the Black Orchid two hours ago. On the back, a label-maker strip: YOU WERE SEEN TOGETHER. No signature. No theatrical threats. Just clean, bureaucratic pressure. They weren't coming for me yet. They were just updating my file. I unplugged the drive and shoved it into the Faraday pouch. I picked up the legal pad and wrote two lines in the center of the page: THEY MOVED FASTER THAN I DID. VICTORIA MAY ALREADY BE DEAD. I looked at the .38 again. The digital theory was over. The physical death was just beginning.

I didn't take the elevator. Elevators are just vertical coffins with mirrors, designed to keep you staring at your own decay while the cables decide your fate. I took the fire stairs, my boots echoing against the concrete in a staccato rhythm that sounded like a countdown.

The air in the stairwell tasted like stagnant lungs and industrial floor wax.

I hit the street and didn't look for my car. If they had the photo of the Black Orchid, they had the plates on the Mustang. Instead, I walked three blocks East, weaving through the early morning ghosts of MacArthur Park—men with hollow eyes selling stolen minutes, and pigeons pecking at the discarded wrappers of a city that had already finished its breakfast.

Raoul's "office" was a storefront in a strip mall that the neighborhood had forgotten to demolish. The sign above the door said *Advanced Irrigation Solutions*, which was technically true. Raoul

dealt in the plumbing of human catastrophe. He managed the flow of things that people wanted washed away.

The bell didn't ring when I walked in. Raoul didn't believe in announcing arrivals; he believed in monitoring them.

The room smelled of gun oil, ozone, and the kind of cheap menthol cigarettes that leave a film on your teeth. Raoul was behind the counter, hunched over a rack of server blades that hummed like a hive of angry hornets. He didn't look up. He didn't have to. He had four monitors angled toward him, showing the street, the alley, the roof, and a thermal feed of the front door.

"You look like shit, Duke," Raoul said. His voice was a tectonic shift—gravel and resentment. "Even for a man who lives on a diet of spite and bad decisions."

"The system updated, Raoul. I'm just trying to keep the firmware from crashing."

I tossed the padded envelope onto the counter. He didn't touch it. He looked at the thermal signature of the photo through the plastic.

"Black Orchid," he grunted. "High-end. Controlled. You might as well have held a press conference."

"Victoria Cross handed me a drive. Ten minutes later, someone took that photo. An hour after that, I got a 'Sanitization' bill for the Echo Park safe house. Glendale contractor. Specialist rates."

Raoul finally looked up. His eyes were the color of wet slate. "Sanitization? That's not a PR term, Duke. That's a cleaning crew for the kind of messes that don't have insurance."

"Exactly. They charged thirty-five hundred for 'Hazardous Organic Residue.' They weren't wiping a server. They were bleaching a floor."

I felt the autopsy line beginning to form in my gut—the realization of what that bill actually represented. Thirty-five hundred dollars. In the corporate ledger, that's a rounding error. In a human life, that's the cost of removing the evidence of a struggle. It's the price of a daughter's scream being turned into a line item for 'Deep Clean & Structural Neutralization.' It wasn't murder; it was an infrastructure adjustment.

"Trace the Glendale address," I said. "And the firm. 'Apex Narrative Hygiene.' Check their payroll. See if they're subbing through Kingston Global or if they're a direct wire from the Babylon Circuit."

Raoul's fingers moved across the keyboard with a speed that defied his bulk. "Apex isn't a firm. It's a shell. One of those LLCs that exists just long enough to buy the bleach and then dissolves back into the ether. But the address in Glendale... it's a warehouse near the tracks. Zone 4. Industrial."

"Who owns the Zone?"

"A holding company called 'Continuity Holdings.' Based in Nevada. The same trust that funded the Kingdom Cares gala."

The serpent watermark again. The stylized coil. It wasn't just a logo; it was the signature of the ownership.

"They moved on Victoria," I said. "The photo is a courtesy. They're telling me she's already been 'sequenced.' I need to know if she's at the Glendale site or if she's been 'relocated' to Pallas Medical."

Raoul stopped typing. He looked at me, his face a mask of functional paranoia. "You know what happens at Pallas, Duke. Nobody comes out of there 'credible.' They come out with a chemical lobotomy and a non-disclosure agreement written into their nervous system."

"Then we don't let her get there."

"We?" Raoul let out a dry, hacking laugh. "I'm the quartermaster, Savage. I provide the tools. I don't go into the meat grinder."

"I'm not asking you to carry a gun. I'm asking you to kill the feed. If Apex is a shell, it's using a digital backbone. I need a blackout in Glendale. Ten minutes. Just enough to let me see what's behind the 'Hazardous Organic' curtain without the Circuit watching me do it."

Raoul turned back to the screens. The red glow of the server lights reflected in his eyes, making him look like a demon in a basement.

"Ten minutes," he muttered. "But it'll cost you. Not money. I need the drive Victoria gave you. I need to see the Disbursement File. My name is in there too, Duke. I can feel the itch."

I looked at the .38 on the counter—the physical anchor. Then I looked at the flickering screens.

"Everyone's name is in there, Raoul. We're just the only ones who know we're being read."

I handed him the Faraday pouch.

"Don't open the audio files on a live network," I warned. "Or we'll both be 'sanitized' before noon."

Raoul didn't respond. He was already drowning in the data, his face illuminated by the cold, blue light of the indictment. I left the shop, the bell still silent, the Los Angeles sun finally breaking through the smog like a spotlight on a stage that had already been set for a tragedy.

The Mustang didn't feel like a car anymore. It felt like a tracking beacon with an exhaust leak. Every stoplight was a witness, every CCTV camera a stenographer for the Circuit. I drove with the .38 wedged between the seat and the console, the cold steel a necessary counterweight to the sun-drenched fraud of a Los Angeles morning.

Glendale in the AM is where the city's industrial colon resides. It's a landscape of tilt-up concrete, chain-link fences weeping rust, and warehouses that sit low and mute, as if they'd signed non-disclosure agreements with hell itself. This wasn't the L.A. of the postcards; this was the L.A. of the invoices—the place where the things that make the lifestyle possible are stored, serviced, and, if necessary, buried.

I pulled onto a side street two blocks from the Apex address. The air smelled of diesel, hot asphalt, and the metallic tang of a nearby scrap yard. I didn't see any "Narrative Hygiene" signage. The system doesn't advertise its erasers.

The warehouse was a windowless slab of grey stone with a single loading bay and a steel personnel door. A white van was backed into the bay, its rear doors open. No logos. No plates. Just a clean, anonymous tool for a clean, anonymous job.

I checked my watch. Raoul's ten-minute window hadn't started yet.

I sat in the heat, the sweat tracing a slow, itchy path down my spine. This was the part the movies get wrong. They make the wait look like tension. It's not tension; it's an audit of every mistake you've ever made. I looked at the warehouse and didn't see architecture. I saw a "Sanitization" workflow.

The van was the intake. The personnel door was the processing. The lack of windows was the "Narrative Weather Mitigation." Inside that box, truth was being updated around whatever was left of Victoria Cross.

I thought about the \$3,500 bill. For that price, you don't just get a mop and a bucket. You get a crew that knows how to treat "Hazardous Organic Residue" like it's a spilled latte. They don't see a person; they see a liability that needs to be neutralized before the morning briefing.

My phone buzzed. A text from a burner: *GRID IS DARK. 600 SECONDS. DONT BE A HERO, BE AN EXIT.*

I didn't wait. I was out of the car and moving before the screen dimmed.

The silence of a dead security grid is a specific kind of quiet. The hum of the cameras stops. The magnetic locks click with a sound like a bone breaking. It's the sound of the system blinking.

I reached the personnel door. It was heavy, industrial-grade steel designed to keep the world out, but Raoul had turned it into a suggestion. It yielded with a low, hydraulic groan.

The interior was a cathedral of clinical violence.

Fluorescent lights flickered, struggling against Raoul's blackout, casting long, jittery shadows across the floor. The smell hit me first—not blood, but something worse. High-grade medical bleach and the synthetic citrus of industrial deodorizer. It was the smell of a lie being manufactured in real-time.

The space was divided by heavy plastic sheeting—thick, translucent barriers that looked like skin stretched over a wound. Behind the plastic, I saw the silhouettes of equipment: industrial vacuums, pressurized sprayers, and a stainless-steel table that caught the dying light.

This wasn't a warehouse. It was a de-contextualization chamber.

I moved past the first plastic veil, the .38 leading the way. My boots made a wet, sticky sound on the floor. I looked down. The floor was spotless, but it was still damp. They'd already started.

That's when I saw the "Inventory."

A pile of clothes sat in a plastic bin near the table. A silk blouse, charcoal grey. A pair of Gucci heels, one of them with a snapped stiletto. A leather handbag, emptied and sorted like evidence in a cold case.

Victoria's Gucci.

I didn't feel anger. Anger is a luxury for people who still believe the truth matters. I felt a cold, predatory clarity. The autopsy had moved from the drive to the room.

I followed the sound of a low, rhythmic thudding from the back of the space. It wasn't a heartbeat. It was a machine—a heavy-duty shredder, the kind they use for "High-Security Document Destruction."

Except they weren't shredding paper.

A man in a white Tyvek suit was standing by the machine, his back to me. He was feeding something into the maw—something that looked like a stack of personal journals, the leather covers being chewed into confetti. Beside him, a second man was hosing down a plastic-wrapped bundle on a gurney.

They moved with the casual efficiency of postal workers. No malice. No drama. Just two guys finishing a shift before the narrative stabilized.

"Hey," I said. My voice sounded like it came from the bottom of a well.

The man in the Tyvek suit didn't jump. He didn't reach for a gun. He just turned, his face obscured by a respirator, and looked at me with the bored eyes of a man interrupted during his lunch break.

"Area's restricted," he said through the mask. "We're in the middle of a Tier 3 Neutralization."

"I know," I said, thumbing the hammer back on the .38. "I'm here to audit the residue."

The man with the respirator didn't reach for a weapon. He didn't even drop the hose. He just stood there in his white plastic suit, looking at me with the clinical boredom of a man who had seen better gunmen than me get erased by a single keystroke in a Century City office.

"You're late, Savage," he said. The voice was muffled, filtered through charcoal and corporate indifference. "The intake was logged at 0400. You're working on a legacy timeline. We're already in the stabilization phase."

"Where is she?" I asked. I didn't look at the gurney. I didn't want to see the shape under the plastic. If I looked, the theory became a fact, and I wasn't ready for that kind of math yet.

"Victoria Cross is no longer a localized variable," the second man said. He was smaller, his Tyvek suit crinkling as he moved toward a wall-mounted tablet that was currently dark. "She's been transitioned to a Tier 3 facility for 'narrative alignment.' What you see here is just the residue. The physical leftovers. The stuff that doesn't fit the new version of the truth."

I stepped closer, the .38 heavy in my grip. I used the barrel to hook the edge of the plastic sheeting on the gurney. I pulled it back.

It wasn't a body.

It was a mannequin. A high-fidelity, medical-grade silicon proxy, dressed in a replica of the silk blouse I'd seen in the bin. Beside it lay a series of "Asset-Adjacent" props: a burner phone, a vial of pills with a forged prescription, and a printed suicide note that looked like it had been written by a woman drowning in guilt and procedure.

The autopsy hit me with the force of a physical blow. They weren't just killing her; they were recasting her. This wasn't a murder scene. It was a rehearsal.

"The photo at the Black Orchid," I muttered, the pattern recognition finally clicking into place. "It wasn't a threat. It was a costume check."

"We don't kill people, Savage," the man with the respirator said. He finally turned off the hose. The synthetic citrus smell was deafening now. "That's messy. That's 1990s logic. We just provide a more sustainable version of their exit. By tomorrow morning, Victoria Cross will have been a woman on the edge for months. Her digital footprint, her bank records, her 'unstable' messages to her handler—it's all being back-dated as we speak. This is the 'Hazardous Organic Residue'—the truth that doesn't match the file."

He gestured to the pile of Victoria's real clothes, her real journals, her real life being fed into the shredder.

"You can't shoot a workflow, Duke," the smaller one added. "Raoul's blackout? That was factored in. A ten-minute 'maintenance window.' It gave us just enough time to let you see the mannequin. To let you understand that the woman you're looking for doesn't exist anymore. She's been corrected."

I looked at the mannequin's face—a blank, silicon stare that had been molded to look like a woman who had given up. It was the "Authorized Truth" in the flesh. Or rather, in the plastic.

The lights in the warehouse flickered and surged back to life. The hum of the security grid returned, a low, electronic growl that signaled Raoul's window had slammed shut. I was no longer a ghost in the machine. I was a trespasser in a high-security de-contextualization zone.

"You should go," the respirator man said. He picked up a fresh roll of tape. "We have a deadline for the morning news cycle. Victoria's 'final' message is scheduled for 0800. You don't want to be in the frame when the story goes live."

I backed away, the .38 still raised, though it felt useless now—a prehistoric tool in a war fought with algorithms and bleach. I looked at the shredder one last time. The leather covers of Victoria's journals were gone, turned into grey dust that looked like ash.

I didn't say anything. There were no "Gonzo" quips left in the chamber.

I ran.

I hit the street as the Glendale sun began to burn through the smog with a vengeful, white heat. The Mustang was where I'd left it, but I knew the plates were already being flagged in a dozen different databases. I wasn't a journalist anymore. I wasn't even a detective. I was just another piece of "Hazardous Organic Residue" that the system hadn't finished scrubbing yet.

I got into the car, my hands shaking against the steering wheel. I checked the .38. It was still loaded. It was the only thing in the world that hadn't updated its narrative.

I pulled away from the curb, watching the white van in the rearview mirror. As I hit the corner, my phone buzzed. A news alert.

*BREAKING: MISSING KINGSTON EXECUTIVE VICTORIA CROSS LINKED TO
DISSEMINATION OF FORGED DOCUMENTS. FAMILY CITES MENTAL HEALTH CRISIS.*

They hadn't just moved faster than I did. They had already finished.

I didn't go back to the office. I didn't call Julie. I drove toward the only place in the city where the invoices don't matter—the ocean. But even the Pacific looked like it had been color-graded for a charity gala.

We didn't expose the system. We just gave it a reason to show us how fast it could heal.